



Janmejaya Sinha
CHAIRMAN, BCG INDIA

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“India has used its presidency to highlight that... [it] is the partner of choice for countries and companies alike”

G20 SHOULDN'T RESTRICT ITSELF TO RESOLUTIONS

India has taken some noteworthy initiatives during its G20 presidency and has not shied away from tough discussions

PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI invoked the Sanskrit term “*Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*” (the world is one family) as India took over the presidency of the G20 (group of 20 nations). That is why India has stated that the theme of its presidency will be “One Earth, One Family, One Future”. Addressing the G20 Foreign Ministers’ meeting in India, Prime Minister Modi asserted that the post-World War II multilateral order is in crisis. The two main objectives of post-WWII multilateralism—to prevent wars by balancing diverging interests and to engender international cooperation on issues of common global interest—have not been achieved. If we were to study the experience of the last few years, we have been witness to a global financial crisis, rapid global warming, a devastating pandemic, all forms of terrorism, and a war in mainland Europe. The G20 platform needs to take leadership in facing up to such challenges. The G20’s approach should be to find ways to build on our shared agreements, rather than focus all our energies on the differences between some of us on some issues. At this time, as a planet, we are falling behind in our commitment to meet the Sustainable Development Goals (SDG) that all nations agreed to at the 2012 United Nations Conference on Sustainable Development in Rio de Janeiro. So, in a sense India’s cry, as a voice for the Global South, is to use the more broad-based G20 platform to advance the world on the most critical global issues facing it. It is in this vein that India has also made an unequivocal push to include the African Union as a permanent member of the G20.

Yet it is important to take a step back and reflect on what the G20 platform is. G20 is a body that can influence and urge, but cannot assert—after all, the resolutions taken by this group are, in fact, non-binding in nature. Therefore, it seeks consensus to influence global decision-making. It is the agility in the identification of priority areas, the participation of a wide stakeholder group (ranging from world leaders, policymakers, the private sector, and common citizens), and the leadership opportunity given to every member nation through a rotating presidency that make it possibly the single-largest and most relevant forum on global decision-making and priority setting. India has tried from the get-go to make its presidency one that is driven by strong leadership and an outcome-oriented focus. The prime minister has led from the front and the Indian G20 Sherpa Amitabh Kant is known for his undying energy. So, one hopes that despite widening geopolitical differences today, the world and the G20 will not be restricted to just resolutions and commitments.